

# FROM CRISIS TO TRIUMPH

Dinesh Kumar Khara stewarded SBI through multiple challenges during his tenure, while ensuring that profits tripled, productivity soared, and the bank consolidated its global standing

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| 39

**D**INESH KUMAR KHARA stepped into the corner office of State Bank of India (SBI) in October 2020, just before he confronted one of the toughest challenges of his career—the devastating second wave of Covid-19. At that time, SBI faced a range of challenges, particularly concerns about how the balance sheet would appear in light of the lockdowns.

“Maintaining employee morale and ensuring uninterrupted services in every corner of the country were significant priorities. The approach was collaborative, involving team members and recognising their contributions while aligning them with the organisation’s purpose,” says Khara, who demitted

office in August this year.

True leadership shines in times of crisis, and Khara’s leadership skills were on full display during that challenging period. His major focus was on asset quality, which was a recurring theme in all his communications to employees. “This wasn’t limited to statements; support from the corporate centre played a crucial role in identifying pitfalls and high-risk geographies. The collaborative effort, coupled with a solutions-oriented approach, helped secure employee commitment and kept the organisation moving forward,” says Khara.

The result: during the four years he was at the helm of the country’s largest bank by assets, SBI’s annual profit skyrocketed by 200%, from

₹20,410 crore in FY21 to a staggering ₹61,077 crore in FY24, while the net NPA plunged from 1.50% to 0.57% in the same period. In the last four years, the bank has earned a combined net profit of ₹1.63 lakh crore. The same for the 64 years before that was ₹1.45 lakh crore.

It’s no surprise then that the jury of the BT-KPMG study unanimously chose Khara for this year’s Lifetime Achievement Award. “Khara has always been a diligent professional who believed in delivering results,” says Pallav Mohapatra, MD & CEO of Arcil and Khara’s former colleague at SBI.

The higher profits also had a cascading impact on the stock performance. SBI’s market cap rose from ₹1.75 lakh crore in FY21